

Kumar Mangalam Birla and Aditya Birla Education Trust Founder and Chairperson Neerja Birla, was struck by a situation where a girl across the road barely had the means to survive.

Of course, “being a young girl in an industry dominated by men” was not easy. “I embarked on the journey to demonstrate my capability in accomplishing things independently and affirm my worthiness of the opportunities afforded to me,” is how Birla puts it. The numbers corroborate this story: over 5 million clients across 100,000 villages with disbursements in excess of ₹21,500 crore since inception or a CAGR of 67 per cent in the FY18-23 period.

This year, Birla joined the boards of Aditya Birla Management Corporation, Grasim Industries and Aditya Birla Fashion & Retail. Besides, she says with the recent acquisition of Chaitanya India Fin Credit, Svatantra has become the second-largest NBFC MFI in India.

It’s not all work for Birla though. She’s also a singer, and a turning point in that career came when her single *Meant to Be* went platinum in India. Given that she was always told there was no market for English music in India, the acceptance really meant something.

The other piece that keeps her occupied is design. It led to Ikai Asai, an artisanal home décor and tableware brand that she founded. Plus, during the pandemic, she founded the Ananya Birla Foundation, with the aim of “forging a realm of compassion, equality and inclusivity”. It has a programme to provide resources across sectors—mental health, equality, education, financial inclusion, climate change and humanitarian relief efforts. Clearly, Birla has just got started. **BT**

@krishnagopalan

Culture Chemist

Anupriya Acharya has been a name in the ad industry and she isn’t ready to slow down just yet

BY KRISHNA GOPALAN

PHOTO BY MANDAR DEODHAR



ANUPRIYA ACHARYA

53, CEO, Publicis Groupe, South Asia

IF THINGS HAD been left to fate, Anupriya Acharya would have been teaching chemistry today. In fact, she did exactly that right after her Master’s in Chemistry from IIT Roorkee.

Growing up in Dehradun and a science degree meant a job at ONGC or teaching. She chose the latter and was at it for a few years after marriage took her to Chennai. “It was clear to me that growth would be difficult,” she says. One thing led to another and she landed a job in Ogilvy & Mather’s media department.

She moved to Delhi and then Mumbai with stints at Mindshare Fulcrum and Group M before joining Publicis’s ZenithOptimedia in 2013. Three years

WHAT KEEPS ME GOING

The energy of people, ideas, and laughter—mixed with unlearning and learning every single day

A LIFE LESSON LEARNT ON THE JOB

Nothing ventured, nothing gained

later, she took charge as Publicis Media’s CEO. “I was lucky to see many stages starting with the emergence of cable and satellite television to a very different world today,” she says.

Her responsibility has since been magnified as CEO of Publicis Groupe, South Asia. That means overseeing pretty much everything. “It keeps me at the cutting edge since there are so many cultural changes,” she says. The only downside is that there’s less time to indulge the fitness freak in her. **BT**

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